

THEME 3 · B1+/B2

# Amazing Stories

3A Hard Work Pays Off — talking about past abilities, being/becoming accustomed to something, persuasion

3B Make Your Own Luck — sharing amazing true stories, expressing opinions

## Warm-up

Look at the title: Amazing Stories. What do you think we will talk about in this theme?  
Tell your partner two ideas.

VOCABULARY

# New words

20 target words

# persistence

n.



**azim, sebat**

*It was pure persistence, not luck, that got her through medical school.*

# breakthrough

n.



**büyük atılım, ıır aan gelişme**

*His breakthrough came after fifteen years of failed experiments.*

# against the odds

idiom



**tüm olumsuzluklara rağmen**

*Against the odds, the young inventor built a working prototype in her garage.*

# by chance

prep. phrase



## tesadüfen

*By chance, the scientist noticed something unusual while cleaning her equipment.*

# at a glance

prep. phrase



## bir bakışta

*At a glance, the old photograph looked ordinary, but it hid an extraordinary secret.*

# self-taught

adj.



## kendi kendini yetiştirmiş

*The self-taught musician never had a single lesson before her first concert.*

# determination

n.



**kararlılık**

*It took years of determination for him to walk again after the accident.*

# remarkable

adj.



**olağanüstü, dikkat çekici**

*She made a remarkable recovery that doctors couldn't fully explain.*

# convince

v.



## ikna etmek

*It took hours to convince the investors that the idea would actually work.*

# credible

adj.



## inandırıcı, güvenilir

*The story sounded unlikely at first, but the evidence made it entirely credible.*

# get used to

phr. v. (transitive)



**bir şeye alışmak (süreç)**

*It took him months to get used to living in a completely different climate.*

# be used to

phr. v. (transitive)



## bir şeye alışkın olmak (durum)

*After years abroad, she is used to speaking three languages every day.*

# figure out

phr. v. (transitive)



**çözmek, anlamak**

*It took the team months to figure out why the engine kept failing.*

# carry on

phr. v. (intransitive)



## devam etmek

*Even after the setback, she decided to carry on with her research.*

# look back

phr. v. (intransitive)



## geriye dönüp bakmak

*When he looks back on those years, he can't believe how far he's come.*

# turn out

phr. v. (intransitive)



**sonuçlanmak, ortaya çıkmak**

*The strange letter turned out to be the beginning of an incredible friendship.*

# slightly

adv. (degree modifier)



## biraz, hafifçe

*The results were slightly better than the scientists had expected.*

# fairly

adv. (degree modifier)



## oldukça

*The idea seemed fairly ordinary until they tested it properly.*

# extremely

adv. (degree modifier)



**son derece, aşırı**

*The journey to find him turned out to be extremely difficult.*

# absolutely

adv. (degree modifier)



## kesinlikle, tamamen

*Everyone agreed the story was absolutely incredible.*

Quick game · What's the word?

“ikna etmek”

a at a glance

b convince

c figure out

Quick game · What's the word?

“tesadüfen”

**a** by chance

**b** turn out

**c** extremely

Quick game · What's the word?

“kararlılık”

a extremely

b determination

c turn out

Quick game · What's the word?

“kendi kendini yetiştirmiş”

a at a glance

b fairly

c self-taught

Quick game · What's the word?

“sonuçlanmak, ortaya çıkmak”

**a** turn out

**b** self-taught

**c** determination

Quick game · What's the word?

“biraz, hafifçe”

**a** slightly

**b** persistence

**c** look back

GRAMMAR

# Past Ability & Being/Becoming Accustomed To

## Notice

As a child, she **could** already solve maths problems that confused adults.

After months of practice, he finally **was able to** repair the old radio himself.

By the time she moved to the city, she **was used to** working long, unpredictable hours.

It took him almost a year to **get used to** writing with his left hand after the accident.

**Which sentences describe a general ability someone had in the past, which describe a single successful achievement, and which describe becoming or being familiar with something?**

## Complete the rule

Look at the Notice sentences again. Complete the rule with the words in the box.

**a general past ability**

**one specific achievement**

**already familiar (a state)**

**the process of becoming familiar**

Complete the rule

'Could' + verb describes \_\_\_\_\_ .

✓ a general past ability

Complete the rule

**'Was/were able to' + verb often describes \_\_\_\_\_, especially when there was some difficulty.**

**✓ one specific achievement**

Complete the rule

'Be used to' + -ing describes being \_\_\_\_\_.

✓ **already familiar (a state)**

Complete the rule

**'Get used to' + -ing describes \_\_\_\_\_ .**

**✓ the process of becoming familiar**

## The rule

**'Could'** describes a general past ability. **'Was/were able to'** describes one specific achievement, often despite difficulty. **'Be used to + -ing'** describes an existing state of familiarity, while **'get used to + -ing'** describes the process of becoming familiar with something.

**TR** Geçmişteki genel bir yeteneği anlatmak için 'could' kullanılır. Belirli, tek bir başarıyı (özellikle zorluğa rağmen) anlatmak için 'was/were able to' kullanılır. 'Be used to + -ing' bir duruma zaten alışkın olmayı, 'get used to + -ing' ise o duruma alışma sürecini ifade eder.

**When?** Use 'could' for a general childhood or long-term ability; use 'was/were able to' for one difficult achievement; use 'be used to' for an existing state of familiarity; use 'get used to' for the process of becoming familiar with something new.

**TR** Genel bir çocukluk yeteneğini anlatırken 'could'; tek seferlik, zor bir başarıyı anlatırken 'was/were able to'; birine zaten alışkın olduğunu belirtirken 'be used to'; yeni bir duruma alışma sürecini anlatırken 'get used to' kullanılır.

Build sentences · Example

she

+

could / read fluently

+

by the age of four

**She could read fluently by the age of four.**

## Build sentences

against the odds, the climber

+

be able to / reach the summit

+

despite the storm

**Against the odds, the climber was able to reach the summit  
despite the storm.**

## Build sentences

as a boy, he

+

could / repair engines

+

without any training

**As a boy, he could repair engines without any training.**

## Build sentences

after years at sea, the sailor

+

be used to / sleeping

+

in rough weather

**After years at sea, the sailor was used to sleeping in rough weather.**

## Build sentences

it took her months + get used to / living + in a completely new country

**It took her months to get used to living in a completely new country.**

## Build sentences

? / the inventor + ever / be able to / convince +  
the investors on the first try

**Was the inventor ever able to convince the investors on the first try?**

## Your turn

Write four sentences about yourself or someone you know: one about a general childhood ability, one about a single achievement, and two about getting or being used to something new.

As a child, I could...

After a lot of practice, I was finally able to...

I'm still not used to...

It took me a while to get used to...

# Form

**POSITIVE**

She could speak three languages by the age of ten.

He was able to finish the marathon despite the injury.

They are used to working under pressure.

I'm getting used to the new schedule.

**NEGATIVE**

He couldn't swim before he took up the sport.

She wasn't able to convince them at first.

We aren't used to such extreme weather.

I still haven't got used to waking up so early.

**QUESTION**

Could you read before you started school?

Was she able to finish the project on time?

Are you used to the new system yet?

Did it take long to get used to the change?

**SHORT ANSWERS**

Yes, I could. / No, I couldn't.

Yes, she was. / No, she wasn't.

Yes, I am. / No, not yet.

## Error detective

**After years of training, she could finally win the competition.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **After years of training, she was finally able to win the competition.**

Error detective

**I am used to wake up early now.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **I am used to waking up early now.**

## Error detective

**She used to living in a big city, so the small town felt strange.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **She wasn't used to living in a big city, so the small town didn't feel strange. / She used to live in a big city.**

A · Choose the correct option.

**As a young girl, Elena \_\_\_\_\_ compose short pieces of music by ear.**

**a** could

**b** was able to

**c** is used to

A · Choose the correct option.

**Despite the broken equipment, the team \_\_\_\_\_ finish the experiment on time.**

**a** could

**b** was able to

**c** used to

A • Choose the correct option.

After ten years abroad, he \_\_\_\_\_ speaking a mix of three languages every day.

a could

b is used to

c was able to

B · Complete with the correct form.

It took her almost a year to \_\_\_\_\_ (get used to) living without electricity on the island.

✓ **get used to**

B · Complete with the correct form.

Against the odds, the young scientist \_\_\_\_\_ (be able to) publish her first paper at seventeen.

✓ **was able to**

B · Complete with the correct form.

As a child, he \_\_\_\_\_ (can) recognise every bird in the forest by its call.

✓ could

C · Judge the sentence.

**After months of practice, she could finally perform the piece perfectly at the concert.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **After months of practice, she was finally able to perform the piece perfectly at the concert.**

C · Judge the sentence.

**He still isn't used to work such long hours.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **He still isn't used to working such long hours.**

C · Judge the sentence.

**As a teenager, she could already fix almost any bicycle.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

Dialogue · Complete with the correct form.

**A: \_\_\_\_\_ (can) you read music before you joined the orchestra?**

**✓ Could**

Dialogue · Complete with the correct form.

**B: A little, yes. But it took me months to really \_\_\_\_\_ (get used to) sight-reading fast enough.**

✓ **get used to**

Dialogue · Reorder the sentence.

**odds / the / against / finish / able / to / race / she / was / the**

the

odds,

able

finish

to

against

she

race

the

was

.

✓ **Against the odds, she was able to finish the race.**

GRAMMAR

# Degree Modifiers: Slightly, Fairly, Extremely, Absolutely

## Notice

The results were only **slightly** better than the team had expected.

Her first attempt was **fairly** successful, but far from perfect.

The whole project turned out to be **extremely** difficult in the end.

Everyone agreed that his recovery was **absolutely** incredible.

**Which degree modifiers make an adjective a little stronger, which make it moderately strong, which make it very strong, and which are only used with 'extreme' adjectives that already mean 100%?**

## Complete the rule

Complete the rule with the words in the box.

**gradable adjectives**

**ungradable (extreme) adjectives**

**a small degree**

**a very high degree**

Complete the rule

**'Slightly' and 'fairly' are typically used with \_\_\_\_\_ (e.g. good, difficult, successful), which can exist in degrees.**

**✓ gradable adjectives**

Complete the rule

**'Extremely' also modifies gradable adjectives, showing**

\_\_\_\_\_ .

✓ **a very high degree**

**Complete the rule**

**'Absolutely' is typically used with \_\_\_\_\_ (e.g. incredible, amazing, impossible), which already mean 100% and cannot be 'more' or 'less'.**

**✓ ungradable (extreme) adjectives**

## The rule

**Degree modifiers show how strong an adjective is. 'Slightly' (a little) and 'fairly' (moderately) are used with gradable adjectives (good, difficult); 'extremely' is also used with gradable adjectives but shows a very high degree. 'Absolutely' is used with ungradable/extreme adjectives that already mean 100% (incredible, impossible, amazing).**

**TR** Derece zarfları (degree modifiers) bir sıfatın gücünü belirtir. 'Slightly' (hafifçe) ve 'fairly' (oldukça) derecelendirilebilen sıfatlarla (good, difficult) kullanılır; 'extremely' (son derece) da aynı tür sıfatlarla ama çok güçlü bir derece belirtir. 'Absolutely' (kesinlikle) ise zaten %100 anlamı taşıyan, derecelendirilemeyen sıfatlarla (incredible, impossible, amazing) kullanılır.

**When?** We use degree modifiers when we want to be precise about how strong a quality is — for example, how surprising a story is, or how difficult an achievement was.

**TR** Bir durumun ne kadar 'derecede' olduğunu netleştirmek istediğimizde, örneğin bir hikayenin ne kadar şaşırtıcı ya da bir başarının ne kadar zor olduğunu anlatırken derece zarflarını kullanırız.

Build sentences · Example

the story

+

absolutely / incredible

+

everyone agreed

**Everyone agreed the story was absolutely incredible.**

Build sentences

the first results

+

slightly / disappointing

+

compared to expectations

**The first results were slightly disappointing compared to expectations.**

## Build sentences

his plan

+

fairly / risky

+

but not impossible

**His plan was fairly risky, but not impossible.**

## Build sentences

the journey across the desert + extremely / dangerous +  
according to the guide

**According to the guide, the journey across the desert was extremely dangerous.**

## Build sentences

the ending of the story

+

absolutely / unbelievable

+

when you hear it

**The ending of the story is absolutely unbelievable when you hear it.**

**Build sentences**

**? / the challenge**

+

**extremely / difficult**

+

**for the first team**

**Was the challenge extremely difficult for the first team?**

## Your turn

Write four sentences about an amazing story you know or can imagine, using a different degree modifier (slightly, fairly, extremely, absolutely) in each one.

At first, the story seemed only slightly...

Honestly, I found it fairly...

By the end, the situation was extremely...

In my opinion, the whole thing was absolutely...

# Form

## POSITIVE

The story was slightly exaggerated, but mostly true.

Her achievement was absolutely remarkable.

## NEGATIVE

The task wasn't extremely difficult, just fairly time-consuming.

It isn't slightly unusual — it's absolutely astonishing.

## QUESTION

Was the journey extremely dangerous?

Is the story absolutely true, or slightly exaggerated?

## SHORT ANSWERS

Yes, extremely. / No, only slightly.

Yes, absolutely. / No, not really.

Error detective

The ending was very absolutely amazing.

a Correct

b Incorrect

✓ The ending was absolutely amazing.

Error detective

**The plan was absolutely risky.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **The plan was extremely risky. / The plan was fairly risky.**

Error detective

**It was slightly incredible how she survived.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **It was absolutely incredible how she survived.**

A • Choose the correct option.

**Her first attempt at the language exam was \_\_\_\_\_ successful — she passed, but only just.**

**a** absolutely

**b** fairly

**c** utterly

A · Choose the correct option.

**When the truth came out, everyone found the story \_\_\_\_\_ unbelievable.**

**a** slightly

**b** fairly

**c** absolutely

A • Choose the correct option.

The mountain path was \_\_\_\_\_ steeper than the map suggested — nothing dramatic, just a bit more effort.

a absolutely

b slightly

c totally

B · Complete with the correct modifier.

The final challenge turned out to be \_\_\_\_\_ (very high degree)  
difficult, far harder than anyone expected.

✓ **extremely**

B · Complete with the correct modifier.

I found the ending \_\_\_\_\_ (100%) astonishing — I still can't believe it happened.

✓ **absolutely**

B · Complete with the correct modifier.

The interview was \_\_\_\_\_ (moderate degree) interesting, though not the most exciting part of the documentary.

✓ **fairly**

C · Judge the sentence.

**The rescue mission was extremely impossible to complete in one day.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **The rescue mission was absolutely impossible to complete in one day.**

C · Judge the sentence.

**Her progress was slightly noticeable after just one week of practice.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

C · Judge the sentence.

**The whole audience agreed the performance was absolutely brilliant.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

Dialogue · Complete with the correct modifier.

**A: Was the climb \_\_\_\_\_ (very) exhausting?**

**✓ extremely**

Dialogue · Complete with the correct modifier.

**B: Honestly, it was \_\_\_\_\_ (100%) unbearable near the top, but only \_\_\_\_\_ (a little) hard at the start.**

✓ **absolutely / slightly**

Dialogue · Reorder the sentence.

**found / absolutely / the / everyone / astonishing / story**

astonishing

found

the

everyone

story

absolutely

•

✓ **Everyone found the story absolutely astonishing.**

READING

# The Shepherd Who Read the Sky

## Before you read

1. Look at the title. What do you think 'read the sky' might mean?
2. Do you know any true stories about someone who taught themselves a skill?

**THE SHEPHERD WHO READ THE SKY · 1 / 3**

By the age of twelve, Yusuf could already name every visible star from his family's hillside in eastern Anatolia. There was no telescope, no astronomy club, and, at first, barely any books — just long nights spent watching the sky while his family's sheep grazed nearby. What began as a way to pass the time slowly turned into something far more serious.

**THE SHEPHERD WHO READ THE SKY · 2 / 3**

At sixteen, Yusuf was able to build his first basic telescope from spare lenses he found at a market by chance. It was fairly crude, and villagers were slightly amused by the strange contraption pointed at the night sky. Yet within two years, he had taught himself enough physics and mathematics, entirely self-taught from borrowed textbooks, to win a national science competition — a result that surprised everyone except, quietly, Yusuf himself.

**THE SHEPHERD WHO READ THE SKY · 3 / 3**

Today, Yusuf works at an observatory, and he says he still isn't fully used to being called a scientist. 'At a glance, my story might sound like pure luck,' he explains, 'but really it was years of determination that nobody saw.' His journey shows that a breakthrough can begin anywhere — even on a quiet hillside, under a sky full of ordinary stars.

While you read

## What is the main idea of the text?

a

Yusuf became a scientist purely by luck.

b

Persistent self-teaching turned a shepherd's hobby into a scientific achievement.

c

Telescopes are only useful in villages.

While you read

Yusuf found the spare lenses for his first telescope \_\_\_\_\_.

✓ **by chance**

While you read

## How did Yusuf learn the physics and mathematics he needed?

a

At a private science academy

b

Entirely self-taught, from borrowed textbooks

c

From a family member who was a scientist

While you read

**According to the text, Yusuf now feels completely comfortable being called a scientist.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

**✓ According to the text, Yusuf says he still isn't fully used to being called a scientist.**

While you read

Yusuf believes his story was really about years of \_\_\_\_\_ that nobody saw, not just luck.

✓ **determination**

## After you read

1. What degree modifiers can you find in the text? What do they tell you about how the villagers or Yusuf felt?
2. Do you think persistence matters more than natural talent? Why or why not?

READING

# The Letter That Found Its Way Home

## Before you read

1. What do you think 'the letter that found its way home' might refer to?
2. Have you ever heard of a friendship that began completely by accident?

**THE LETTER THAT FOUND ITS WAY HOME · 1 / 3**

In 1987, a woman named Sibel wrote a letter to a pen pal whose address she had copied down slightly incorrectly. The letter should have been lost forever. Instead, by an extraordinary coincidence, it was delivered to a stranger living at almost the exact same street number in a different city — and that stranger, fascinated rather than annoyed, decided to write back.

**THE LETTER THAT FOUND ITS WAY HOME · 2 / 3**

What followed was an absolutely remarkable, decades-long friendship built entirely on letters, and later, emails. The two women were never able to meet in person for over thirty years; work, distance and, at times, simply bad timing kept getting in the way. Then, in the end, a chance business trip finally brought them to the same city at the same time.

## THE LETTER THAT FOUND ITS WAY HOME · 3 / 3

'At a glance, it seems like an ordinary mistake with an unlikely result,' Sibel says now. 'But by the time we finally met, we were used to knowing everything about each other's lives — we just hadn't seen each other's faces yet.' Their story has since been shared thousands of times online, proving that even a small accident can, by chance, turn into something extraordinary.

While you read

## How did Sibel's friendship with the stranger begin?

a They met at work.

b A letter was delivered to the wrong address by mistake.

c They were introduced by a mutual friend.

While you read

Sibel had copied down the pen pal's address \_\_\_\_\_.

✓ **slightly incorrectly**

While you read

**According to the text, the two women met in person within the first year.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

**✓ According to the text, they were not able to meet in person for over thirty years.**

While you read

**By the time they finally met, how did the two women feel about each other's lives?**

**a** They knew almost nothing about each other.

**b** They were used to knowing everything about each other's lives.

**c** They had completely lost touch.

While you read

The text says a small accident can, by chance, turn into something \_\_\_\_\_.

✓ **extraordinary**

## After you read

1. Find two discourse markers (like 'in the end') in the text. What do they signal to the reader?
2. Do you think stories like this are becoming more or less common because of the internet? Why?

LISTENING

# The Marathon at Sixty

## Before you listen

1. Predict: what challenges might a sixty-year-old face when preparing for a marathon?

# The Marathon at Sixty

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

## How far could Aylin's grandmother run before last year?

a A full marathon

b Barely two minutes of jogging

c Ten kilometres easily

While you listen

**Within six months, she was able to run \_\_\_\_\_ without any pain.**

✓ **ten kilometres**

While you listen

**According to Aylin, her grandmother found the training schedule easy from the very beginning.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

**✓ According to Aylin, the training schedule was extremely hard for her grandmother at first.**

While you listen

## How does Aylin describe her grandmother's feeling at the finish line?

a Disappointed

b Absolutely the proudest moment of her life

c Slightly bored

LISTENING

# Found on the Internet

## Before you listen

1. What do you predict this story might be about — a rescue, a reunion, or an invention?

# Found on the Internet

Ses kaydı yakında — transkripti öğretmen okuyabilir.

While you listen

## What is the main topic of Mert's presentation?

a

A fisherman who  
invented a new tool

b

A message in a bottle  
that reached a sailor's  
daughter decades later

c

A newspaper  
competition

While you listen

The fisherman found the bottle stuck in some \_\_\_\_\_.

✓ rocks

While you listen

**According to Mert, the sailor was still alive when the letter was found.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

**✓ According to Mert, the sailor had passed away, but his daughter was still alive.**

While you listen

## How did the letter help the sailor's daughter, according to the presentation?

a

It helped her get used to missing her father in a new way.

b

It gave her his exact location.

c

It made her angry at her father.

**SPEAKING**

## You Won't Believe This...

In pairs, share an amazing true story you know (real or one you've heard/read online) and try to persuade your partner it's worth believing. Use past ability structures (could, was able to), be/get used to, and degree modifiers (slightly, fairly, extremely, absolutely).

**SPEAKING**

## An Amazing Life

Prepare a two-minute talk about someone (real or invented, but realistic) who achieved something amazing against the odds. Explain what they could/couldn't do at first, how they were able to succeed, and what they had to get used to along the way.

## WRITING

# Biography of an Amazing Life

Write a short biography of someone (real or realistic and invented) with an amazing life or success story. Use prepositional phrases (by chance, at a glance) and discourse markers (then, in the end, by the way) to connect the stages of the story.

## WRITING

# Share an Amazing Story Online

Write a post for a story-sharing website, telling a short amazing true story (real or realistic) and persuading readers it's worth reading. Describe what happened and explain why it's so remarkable.

REVIEW

# Exit ticket

## Exit ticket

As a child, Elif \_\_\_\_\_ already play the violin without any lessons.

**a** could

**b** was able to

**c** is used to

## Exit ticket

Despite the heavy rain, the rescue team \_\_\_\_\_ reach the missing hikers before dark.

a could

b was able to

c used to

Exit ticket

It took him months to \_\_\_\_\_ (get used to) living in such a small flat.

✓ get used to

Exit ticket

After years at sea, she \_\_\_\_\_ (be used to) sleeping through the noise of the waves.

✓ was used to

## Exit ticket

The final results were only \_\_\_\_\_ different from the first test.

a absolutely

b slightly

c totally

Exit ticket

**The ending of the story was very absolutely amazing.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **The ending of the story was absolutely amazing.**

Exit ticket

Everyone agreed the recovery was \_\_\_\_\_ (100%) remarkable.

✓ **absolutely**

Exit ticket

**Which sentence correctly uses a degree modifier with a gradable adjective?**

**a** The task was absolutely difficult.

**b** The task was fairly difficult.

**c** The task was absolutely difficultly.

Exit ticket

**Which word means 'having learned a skill by oneself, without formal teaching'?**

**a** self-taught

**b** credible

**c** remarkable

Exit ticket

'Without being planned; accidentally' means \_\_\_\_\_ .

✓ by chance

## Exit ticket

## Put the words in order.

finish

to

the

odds,

race

the

able

was

she

against

•

✓ **Against the odds, she was able to finish the race.**

Exit ticket

**He still isn't used to work such long hours.**

**a** Correct

**b** Incorrect

✓ **He still isn't used to working such long hours.**

Exit ticket

## Rewrite using the correct structure.

(She learned to swim by herself as a child. (self-taught / could))

✓ **She was self-taught, and as a child she could already swim well.**

Exit ticket

The interview was \_\_\_\_\_ (moderate degree) interesting, but not the best part of the show.

✓ fairly